

ENTERTAINMENT

DOCUMENTING LOVE

Karan Johar's *Love Storiyaan* on Prime Video documents real-life couples who overcame the odds to be together

Karan Johar's production banner Dharma is known for its love stories. So, it seems natural that they'd make a documentary series around love. Only Somen Mishra, who heads creative development at both Dharma and Dharmatic, its digital arm, had little idea that it would take as long, if not longer, than a feature to make. Based on the stories featured in *India Love Project* (*ILP*), a social media initiative run by journalists Priya Ramani, Samar Halarnkar and Niloufer Venkatraman, and three and a half years in the making, *Love Storiyaan* sees six half-hour episodes, each devoted to a couple who overcame odds to be happy together.

"In the past few years, love stories have vanished in the popular mainstream, and action or big event films have taken centrestage," says Mishra, who served as producer on last year's *Rocky aur Rani Kii Prem Kahaani*. "In our office, we hear people say we can't watch a show with family because there's too much crime and abuses."

What's immediately noticeable about *Love Storiyaan* is how it ticks the diversity box. There are couplings here across caste, faith, language, economic class, ethnicity, gender spectrum and even nationalities. Mishra further met the diversity criterion while approaching the directors who'd helm each story. Hardik Mehta, much like the couple featured in his short—a Keralite married to a Punjabi—also married outside his community, while Akshay Indikar, who follows Subhadra, a tribal Dalit, and Rahul, a Hindu Brahmin, had an intercaste marriage. There are two stories that take viewers to Kerala, one involving an Afghan man. Another two are set in Kolkata, one centred on a trans couple and another following two radio jockeys in Shillong.

The idea, says Somen Mishra, creative head at Dharma, was to represent a different conflict every episode

The idea, says Mishra, was to "represent a different conflict every episode". *ILP* so far has about 300 stories, which were whittled down to 30-40 for the show. Each filmmaker shortlisted five of his or her preferred real-life romances to direct. Then came the difficult task of convincing the subjects to come on camera. First, Zoom meetings were scheduled with the pairs to break the ice; then the directors travelled to the locations to gain their trust. Only then were the shoots scheduled. "It became cathartic for couples to share their stories," says Mishra. "When you revisit [your journey], you realise what you have gone through."

If there was any apprehension while filming, says Mishra, it was to ensure that the couples "feel comfortable talking". "A lot are in vulnerable places and positions," says Mishra, citing one couple who couldn't be featured because of lack of acceptance from one side of the family. Mishra sees potential for a season two to document more tales that are full of hope, resilience, persistence and that funny thing called love. "People who fall in love and believe in it come what may always tide through things," he says. It explains an alternative title considered for the show— 'Jab Pyaar Kiya Toh Darna Kya'. ■

–Suhani Singh

